

gists and leaders to unfair practices at work, unconscious biases, lack of equal opportunity and more such unfortunate reasons,” says Gangadharan, also the Vice Chairperson of IT industry body Nasscom.

Financial services companies fare better with a gap of 5.8 percentage points. Banking veteran Padmaja Chunduru, MD & CEO of National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL), says that women have to choose between competing priorities of work and family. “The escalating risk and responsibility matrix as they rise in hierarchy causes many to drop out of the race.”

VACUUM AT THE TOP

When poor representation at the top leads to a lack of visible role models, heralding change at the bottom becomes harder. “It is important for a young woman to see other women in critical roles at all levels. At SBI, we all grew in our careers following and observing our seniors take on more and more challenging roles and ac-

ing them,” says Chunduru. But India Inc. is going the extra mile. For Instance, KPMG in India has 30-33 per cent women’s representation at the people management level, and 20 per cent at the top management level, giving its female workforce the “licence to dream”, says Shivsankar.

NSDL, for instance, has ramped up representation from 17 per cent about a year and a half ago to 26 per cent now. “We mandated that at least 30 per cent of the candidates for any open position have to be women and they have to be interviewed by the line managers along with the HR team,” says Chunduru. Meanwhile, SAP India, noticing double-digit churn among women employees after having their second child, built an in-house child care centre ‘SAPLings’.

KPMG’s Shivsankar says many more organisations now consult them for building a leadership pipeline of women. But what is really needed is a comprehensive multi-year plan addressing challenges in

equal opportunities, equal pay and creating an enabling environment. Shivsankar says less than 50 per cent of organisations in India have gender diversity as a strategic priority.

“More organisations are yet to realise how much value can be unlocked through investment in this area. Their outlook becomes an impediment to progress.”

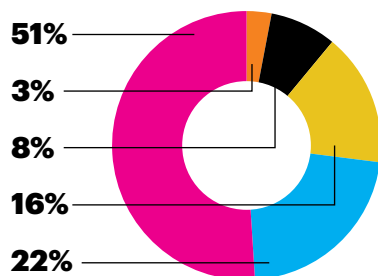
Social barriers and slow organisational change notwithstanding, Chunduru feels the best way to solve the problem is by the woman herself. “The solution begins at home—set realistic expectations of yourself, speak up to have your voice heard, make your own decisions and own them up.”

And the 56 women on this year’s MPWlist—only those who have completed a year in their current position were considered—have done just that. Their journeys, challenges and achievements will serve as inspiring reminders of what is possible. **BT**

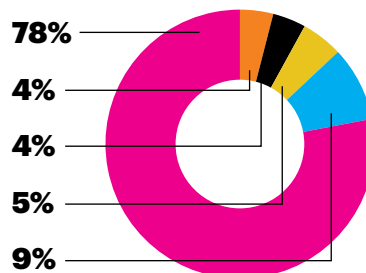
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MIDDLE MANAGEMENT



JUNIOR MANAGEMENT



● <5% ● 5-10% ● 10-15% ● 15-20% ● >20%

LOPSIDED TOP

Despite progress, women’s representation in the top management of Indian companies continues to be low

22%

WOMEN IN THE WHITE-COLLAR WORKFORCE

5%
CEOs WHO
ARE
WOMEN

4%
CFOs WHO
ARE
WOMEN

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